

As a Midnight Earthquake Struck

Northwestern China, Villages Crumbled in the Cold

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December 22, 2023

A magnitude 6.2 earthquake struck northwestern Gansu province just before midnight on Thursday, when most of the lights had already gone out across the mountains of the region.

Some residents said the moon outside their windows appeared to sway, as if the sky itself had tilted. Others remembered only a violent jolt before they were thrown awake. In the darkness that followed, the ground continued to shudder. Within minutes, homes that had stood for decades cracked open or collapsed entirely.

According to official data, the earthquake hit Jishishan County in Gansu province at 11:59 p.m. on December 18. The quake had a shallow focal depth of 10 kilometers, amplifying its destructive force. At least 113 people were confirmed dead and hundreds injured in Gansu. Across the provincial border in neighboring Qinghai, officials reported additional deaths, injuries and missing persons.

By the time the shaking stopped, families were gathering outside in freezing temperatures, lighting small fires to keep warm. Behind them, walls had split apart, roofs had caved in and bricks lay scattered across narrow lanes.

Seventy-six-year-old Liu was not home when the earthquake struck. He had been visiting relatives outside the county that night. By the time he reached his village, he learned that his son and young grandson had been killed when their house collapsed.

Relatives said his daughter-in-law, who was seven months pregnant, survived the initial impact but was struck by falling masonry. She was rushed to a local hospital, but doctors were unable to save her unborn child.

Jishishan sits more than 2,000 meters above sea level, in a remote region shaped by harsh winters and limited resources. For years, many families here built their homes with brick-and-wood structures, supported by wooden beams and hollow bricks that reduced construction costs but offered little resistance to strong tremors.

In towns and villages closest to the epicenter, houses collapsed within seconds. Rescue workers later said most of the victims had been asleep, giving them little chance to escape.

In neighboring areas across the Yellow River in Qinghai province, the earthquake was followed by a second wave of destruction. Villages there were hit not only by tremors but by landslides and mudflows that surged downhill minutes later.

Yang Haiping, who works in the provincial capital, said his family was jolted awake by a deafening crash. "It sounded like thunder," his sister recalled. "The walls shook violently. The floor seemed to ripple beneath their feet. Barely able to stand, the family ran outside into the cold night."

Moments later, they heard a roaring sound grow louder. A torrent of mud swept through nearby homes, carrying debris and earth down natural gullies that cut through the village.

By the following evening, thick brown sludge covered large sections of the settlement. Freezing temperatures had hardened the surface into a brittle crust, while the mud underneath remained wet and unstable. Anyone who stepped into it risked being trapped.

Rescue teams worked through the night, using excavators to clear debris and search for those still missing. Manual digging, rescuers said, was nearly impossible. The mud was heavy, sticky and clung to tools and boots.

Geological researchers said the quake had destabilized water-saturated loess soil common in the region, triggering landslides that traveled long distances before spilling into residential areas. Dozens of houses were buried or destroyed, and rural roads were blocked, slowing rescue efforts.

As dawn broke the next morning, signs of mourning began to appear.

In one village, a funeral was held in the courtyard of a house that had survived the earthquake. Paper wreaths lined the walls. Relatives knelt on the ground, burning joss paper beside a portrait of the deceased. Inside, a eulogy was sung in a local ethnic language, its rhythm steady and subdued.

Nearby, heavy machinery continued to dig through frozen mud and shattered brick. Rescue workers paused only briefly before returning to the ruins.

"These materials are extremely heavy," one rescuer said. "They stick to everything. Without machines, we wouldn't be able to move them."

For many survivors, rebuilding remained a distant concern. As night fell again over the mountains, families gathered once more around small fires, listening for updates and waiting for news of those who had not yet been found.

In the cold, the search continued.

This writing sample is an adapted version of an article originally published on Caixin Weekly.

This article was originally published on Caixin Global on December 18, 2024.

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